because I thought he shared my passion and the goal, I cared a damn when I overheard whispers that ‘Nambi is playing a game.’

A confession: I did play more than a game to ensure that virtually every team member was to my liking. But this in no way compromised on the skill sets of the candidates. I will put it this way: I never selected someone just because I liked him, but I helped a few of my favourites to beat their peers in the final round of selection. Here’s how.

To ensure that no mediocre scientist or engineer got selected, we made the primary criterion that the candidate should have got a ‘very good’ rating for three consecutive years in their annual confidential report. This weeded out a large number of applicants. Having already dubbed it a ‘Nambi show’, the selection process did not get enough participation from some seniors like Gowarikar and Kalam.

While Gowarikar was less adept at masking his disinterest, Kalam played the ‘trust’ card.

‘I am sure you can handle this, you go ahead with the decision,’ Kalam once said when I sought his signature on one of the selection files.

I knew I would go ahead with the decision, but to preempt any hitch, I sat on Kalam’s desk till I got his attestation. This I diligently followed at every juncture of the selection process. I could deal with nasty whispers, but I did not want any hole in the paperwork that would give my detractors a chance to derail the project. I got Gowarikar, too, to sign on the dotted line.

After the initial screening, I played my trump card: let’s have group discussions of the shortlisted candidates. Those watching me closely with suspicion knew what I had in mind, but there was simply nothing in the process that anyone could protest. A group discussion brings out the best in the candidates in a transparent manner, giving no scope for allegations of foul play. At the same time, it gave me an opportunity to stump my detractors.

I did favour a couple of people who I was keen on having in the team since I was convinced of their skill sets and was a bit worried if they would underperform in the group discussion, and hence get rejected. I alerted these